



A COMMUNAL table sits in the middle of Highland Avenue as neighbors enjoy a block party in Altadena.

Altadena neighbors’ bonds move them to stay and rebuild

The Eaton fire destroyed more than half the homes on Highland Avenue. Nearly everyone vowed to return.

By Colleen Shalby

Before the fire, Heather Rutman could look up the street from her frontyard to see if her mom was home. Sometimes when her kids were playing outside and her mom was coming back from the store, they’d jump in her car to go play at Grandma’s house.

In the late afternoon, Highland Avenue came alive with families playing catch, neighbors walking dogs together, children biking and skateboarding. At night, Rutman often joined her neighbor Pearlín De Long on her strolls, catching others along the way. A 30-minute venture could easily turn into an hour of vigorous conversation.

This long block in Altadena — canopied with oaks and camphor trees and bookended by two roads — offered a rare small-town feel in the L.A. metropolis. And the people who landed there planted deep roots.

More than half the neighborhood is gone now. But in the months that passed since the Eaton fire, the neighbors have continued to talk remotely and meet regularly to figure out how to rebuild their little world, where parents raised their kids where they had grown up, where the neighbor who had chickens shared their eggs, where residents of all ages watched annual fireworks shows and gathered at block parties and movie nights.

About 30 homes burned down on this street in the Eaton fire; fewer than 20 remain standing. But 10 months after the fire, nearly every resident has vowed to return.

“We know we have something special,” De Long said. “From the moment we moved in, we knew this was different.” [See Rebuilding, A7]

Corruption indictment stirs questions

Ex-Newsom aide’s charges point to involvement in discrimination case

By JESSICA GARRISON AND SONJA SHARP

An indictment unveiled last week charging Gov. Gavin Newsom’s former chief of staff with political corruption threw California’s top political circles into chaos — and stirred speculation in the state capital about what triggered the federal investigation.

Authorities have not revealed any targets beyond Dana Williamson and two other influential political operatives associated with the state’s most powerful Democrats, all of whom are accused of fraud and siphoning campaign funds for personal use.

But details contained in the indictment and other public records indicate that the FBI and U.S. Department of Justice had a keen interest in Williamson and other operatives’ involvement in the handling of a legal case involving “Corporation 1.” The facts revealed about “Corporation 1” match details of a controversial sex discrimination investigation that the state of California led into one of the world’s largest video game companies, Santa-Monica based Activision Blizzard Inc.

Williamson — an influential deal-maker and one of the state’s premier Democratic political consultants before and after she ran Newsom’s office — was arrested on suspicion of corruption Wednesday. Two longtime associates, lobbyist Greg Campbell, a former high-level staffer in the California Assembly, and Sean McCluskie, a longtime aide to former state Atty. Gen. and U.S. Health and Human Services Secretary Xavier [See Indictment, A8]

Russians’ American refuge is upended

Asylum claims, work documents may not protect L.A. couple from deportation.

By HANNAH FRY

The August sun was already warming Westlake Village when Anton Perevalov dressed in athletic shorts and decided to take an early morning stroll with his miniature pinscher, Ben, while his wife slept.

As he turned right onto Hillcrest Drive — a route he’d taken so many mornings before — an unmarked car stopped in front of him and a man he’d never met emerged and peppered him with questions: “Are you Anton Perevalov?” “Are you a citizen of Russia?”

When Perevalov, 43, answered in the affirmative, two other men exited the car and approached him. One took his phone and the other slapped handcuffs on him, ushering him and Ben into the car. As they drove toward his home, they instructed Perevalov to call his wife so she could come out and get the dog.

Perevalov pleaded with the men, saying that there had to be a mistake. He had documents proving he was legal to live and work in the United States. It didn’t matter, one of the men told him.

“You overstayed your visa,” he said. “You are under arrest and coming with us.”

Tatiana Zaiko sprinted out of the house in her pajamas and slippers, telling her 17-year-old son that his dad had been arrested and to lock the door. She’d be right back, she recalled telling him.

She wasn’t. Friends would later find the boy huddled under his parents’ bed, [See Couple, A9]

Immigration raids hit N.C.

Charlotte officials decry the crackdown. Governor says many detained have no convictions. **NATION, A6**

LAX traffic plan spurs skepticism

Critics say \$1.5-billion project, to finish before Olympics, won’t fix the oft-congested “horse-shoe.” **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Rushdie’s tales of mortality

After memoir on near-fatal attack, author reflects again on life and death — in fiction. **ENTERTAINMENT, E7**

Weather

Some showers. L.A. Basin: 61/55. **B8**

Opinion Voices A16

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com**.

7 85944 10300 9

Compost or chaos? Bins clog L.A. curbs

Going green wasn’t supposed to look like this, residents say

By Sandra McDonald and David Zahniser



THE BINS are an effort to comply with a composting law. One person wrote on X: “I have 5 personally.”

streets and highways, sent mud and rocks sliding onto some canyon roads and made for treacherous driving conditions.

The weather probably contributed to at least two deaths in Northern California and on the Central Coast. But as of Saturday evening, there were no reports of major damage to property in Southern California, including in the burn-scarred neighborhoods of Altadena, Pacific Palisades and Malibu.

As of Saturday afternoon, the storm had dumped 2 to 3 inches of rain across the Greater Los Angeles area, and 3 to 6 inches [See Storm, A10]

Koreatown resident Scott Lyness was well aware that the city of Los Angeles was looking to tackle its food-waste problem.

While bicycling to work, he saw the growing number of green trash bins popping up on curbs. He read the notice sent to his home instructing residents to expect green bins to be delivered at some point.

Still, Lyness was not prepared for what came next: 13 green bins deposited earlier this month outside the apartment building he manages on New Hampshire Avenue. That’s on top of the three bins that the city delivered the previous week at a smaller building he also manages next door, and the two green bins that those properties were already using.

Lyness, 69, who works as a project manager at USC, said the two buildings don’t have anywhere near the room to store so many full-size cans — and don’t generate enough organic waste to fill them. He’s tried to have his tenants contact city offices to say they don’t need them. He said he’s even [See Compost, A10]